

Cabinet: Mercury KOB-142

Price: Rs 2,100

Why we chose this: This cabinet has two extra cooling fans, in addition to the SMPS power supply fan. The SMPS power rating is 300 watts, which was good enough for our configuration. Three 5.25-inch bays and two 3.25-inch bays should be enough for all your drives. Aesthetic colours and button placements make it all too irresistible.

Optical Drive: Lite-On Combo

LTC-48161H

Price: Rs 4,250

Why we chose this: The LTC-48161H reads and writes at 48X, re-writes at 24X, and reads DVDs at 16X—all for Rs 4,250. The bundled software include CD-burning software and PowerDVD. Rock-solid performance and rock-bottom price made this our unanimous choice—everyone who disagreed was quickly clobbered!

Floppy Drive: Sony

Price: Rs 410

Why we chose this: Well, for old times' sake; and also in case we needed to boot using a boot disk, and the CD-ROM drive disobeyed.

Modem: D-Link Internal 56K

Price: Rs 525

Why we chose this: We chose the D-link in particular because of its low cost

and the availability factor. Plus, repair and replacement facilities offered by the vendor were very good. It also gave a decent price-to-performance ratio.

Digit 'Back to Basics' PC

Here's a PC that defines 'Value for Money'. If you are not an avid 3D gamer and your work does not involve graphics or video processing, you will not miss the superfluous power of the more expensive PCs.

Processor: AMD Athlon XP 1800+

Price: Rs 3,350

Why we chose this: Two reasons. One, performance; two, price. It's better than a Celeron 2.0 GHz, and gives performance equivalent to a Pentium 4 1.5 GHz. Based on the Palomino core, its price is absolutely right for the Back to Basics PC. Plus, we could run games and multimedia applications without worrying about the minimum system requirements and resources.

Motherboard: MSI KM2M

Price: Rs 3,750

Why we chose this: This is a neat feature-packed little motherboard that puts others to shame. It has a ProSavage8 2D/3D Graphic Controller, Realtek ALC 650 codec, an AGP slot, and four memory slots—two of which support SDRAM (168-pin) DIMMs, while the others support DDR RAM DIMMs. It supports Ultra DMA 66/100/133 operation modes, and

connects up to four IDE devices. The limitation is that it supports memories of the DDR 266 clock speed only. This leaves the door open for an upgrade to the AMD 2600+.

RAM: Hynix DDR 266 128MBx1 DIMM

Price: Rs 800

Why we chose this: This was the only viable option; other exotic brands burn a hole in the pocket. The Hynix DDR 266 is an above-average performer, and two DIMMs put together met our resource needs adequately.

Hard Drive: Samsung SV0411N 40GB

Price: Rs 3,200

Why we chose this: Samsung drives are good performers and are affordable. This entry-level hard drive comes at a decent Rs 3,200. The only drawback is that it runs at 5,400 rpm, which does not translate into performance equivalent to the other, faster drives. However, it suffices to run applications and play videos.

Graphics Accelerator: Onboard

Why we chose this: We're sticking to the integrated ProSavage8 2D/3D Graphic Controller, since it plays games at low resolutions, and also DVDs—which is just about all the multimedia that this PC can handle.

Keyboard: Logitech keyboard

Price: Rs 275

Why we chose this: Decent-build quality, a reputed name in input devices and the killer price were all the reasons we needed. Although no multimedia or shortcut keys are provided, it met our basic needs.

Mouse: Samsung Scroll Mouse

Price: Rs 300

Why we chose this: A scroll-functional mouse, from a reputed company and a good price-to-performance ratio. What else could we ask for?

Monitor: Samsung 56V

Price: Rs 4,900

Why we chose this: The Samsung 56V was the obvious choice because of its performance as well as the price. It performs as good as the best 15-inch monitor, which is one major reason it was included in this configuration.



A Higher Basics

We have some upgrades for our Back to Basics PC too that we thought would turn it into a nice mid-range PC.

Processor: AMD 2400+

Price: Rs 5,200

The board supports up to AMD 2600+, which is pretty difficult to obtain, so the next best one would be the most suitable upgrade to rev up the performance of the Basics PC.

RAM: Hynix DDR 266 256MB DIMM

Price: Rs 2,150

The recommended amount of memory for Windows XP is 256 MB, which gives a performance increase of at least 5 to 7 percent. This is reflected in the faster load times of applications and games.

Graphics Accelerator: MaxTone GeForce 4 MX 440-8X

Price: Rs 2,600

This video card can play all recent games

without any problems, but at low resolutions. Still, it's quite acceptable for the price at which it retails.

Monitor: LG StudioWorks 700S

A larger screen size makes for a good computing experience. Also, you can get higher refresh rates at higher resolutions, reducing eye-strain when working at a stretch. With 17-inch monitors becoming the accepted norm, and the prices at an all-time low, this upgrade is inevitable.

Speakers: Creative Inspire 2.1

Price: Rs 2,700

This set of speakers is far better than the little Creative SBS 20 twins. The sub-woofer packs in some nice punchy bass, and is complemented by the satellites. The mid and high ranges distort after you raise the volume over the three-fourth level, but then you would rarely need to pump it that high.